

7, A Modest Perspective on the Contemporary Western World

Although as a Chinese individual it is fundamentally impossible for me to comprehend the politics of developed nations profoundly, from my perspective, the conspicuous phenomenon of political polarization (政治极化) currently plaguing Western nations—particularly the United States—is perhaps correlated with the academic community's and the public's persistent lack of cognition regarding "modernity" (现代性).

I have noticed that within the political texts that historically laid the foundational cornerstones of contemporary Western developed nations, the discourse regarding modernity remains relatively superficial. For instance, in the American *Declaration of Independence* (《独立宣言》), the founding fathers proclaimed that "certain truths are self-evident," choosing not to adopt direct didacticism or demonstrative methodologies to persuade the populace. The methodology adopted by the individuals of that era was to appeal to rationality, natural law, shared experiences, and collective values; they utilized rhetorical techniques and emotional resonance, while repetitively emphasizing the absolute necessity for action.

However, the social sciences are ultimately practical sciences. No matter how persuasive a theory might be in its narrative or how rigorous its logic, if it remains untested by history, it remains fundamentally unconvincing. Human beings cannot permanently sustain rationality; immigrants hailing from the five lakes and four seas find it exceedingly difficult to possess identical experiences and values; the passions mobilized by rhetoric and emotional appeals are arduous to sustain prolongedly; and the original necessity for action back then will inevitably be consigned to oblivion by the populace as time progresses. Furthermore, the developmental trajectory of any society can fundamentally never be smooth sailing; when the structural difficulties encountered by economic development are coupled with the deliberate instigation of a minority, the populace easily succumbs to doubting the fundamental values and political system upon which their own nation was founded.

Exactly what does the current state of the Western world look like under the observation of a resident of a non-Western nation like myself? I maintain that Western nations are simultaneously insecure and excessively overconfident; these two seemingly contradictory tendencies are mutually causal.

I characterize them as insecure because Western society ostensibly appears incapable of deducing the genesis of "modernity" from the developmental process of human history. Consequently, they fail to firmly convince themselves that their own success is the inevitable culmination of protracted historical development, rather than something dictated by short-term events. I indeed comprehend their anxiety; after all, the "Marxist-Leninists" (马克思列宁主义者) of the preceding century persistently attempted to propagate a deterministic perspective—asserting that history is an evolutionary process possessing a predetermined direction and ultimate purpose—and genuinely inflicted phenomenally colossal devastation. Yet this dread might inevitably mutate into a state of "seeing imaginary fears" (杯弓蛇影); this brings fundamentally zero benefit to humanity's endeavor to comprehend itself. As this manuscript explicitly demonstrates, we are entirely capable of exploring potentially existing universal laws without hypothetically assuming that the historical evolution of various societies possesses a unified direction and purpose.

I characterize them as overconfident because, since Western society has evolved to the stage of **modern society** (现代社会), they paradoxically harbor a fanatical obsession with discussing "postmodernity" (后现代性) while fundamentally lacking a cogent comprehension of even "modernity." I can identically comprehend this hubris; after all, the colossal shockwaves generated by the triumph of the Cold War and the technological revolution upon Westerners were indeed monumental. The problem is: if people remain utterly clueless regarding exactly how the "modern" emerged in the first place, then exactly how can they possibly know what constitutes the "post-modern"? Indulging in discussions of postmodernity makes it exceedingly difficult not to make the perspectives of progressives appear excessively heretical in the eyes of a substantial proportion of the populace, which patently hands conservatives rhetorical ammunition. Driven by their dread and revulsion toward "aimless and unbridled progress," the populace might very well defect to the conservative camp, thereby causing what should be the brakes to morph into the reverse gear.

If the Western world could genuinely realize that they have, in reality, failed to even research modernity comprehensively, and redirect their gaze back toward those fundamental questions that ought to have yielded conclusive answers eons ago, then a phenomenally substantial portion of the causes precipitating political polarization would already be resolved. Precisely as this manuscript articulates: the absolute moment we recognize the existence of unified sociological laws through the observation of history, it suffices to colossally augment people's confidence in universal values.

Westerners at the very least ought to possess a rock-solid confidence, rather than perpetually oscillating between megalomania and an inferiority complex exactly as people observe today. In this manner, people could at least ideologically pull the excessively radical left-wing factions back a bit, drag the excessively reactionary right-wing factions forward a bit, and enable the already polarized democratic politics to achieve some degree of mitigation. Naturally, attempting to resolve the predicaments confronting democratic nations ultimately must materialize in the economic domain, which is fundamentally not something an outsider like myself can dictate.

When I initially put pen to paper to author this manuscript, my primary aspiration was merely to utilize the various nations of the world as a mirror to illuminate the past and present reality of China. Yet as I approach the final strokes, I discovered that for the other nations across the globe, is China not identically a mirror capable of vividly illuminating themselves? I now visceral feel, originating from the profound depths of my heart, that the destinies of all nations and all ethnicities of humanity are inextricably intertwined; yet the mutual comprehension among us remains far too scant. Everyone resides within the identical Global village (地球村), yet we gaze upon one another exactly as strangers; viewed from this perspective, globalization has not progressed too excessively, but rather, it is still far, far from enough!

I have previously mentioned several times exactly why I resolutely oppose racism; in reality, my perspective on racism forms a conspicuous contrast with the mainstream views of contemporary Western society.

From my perspective, opposing racism is primarily an opposition to ignorance rather than a moral critique. The history of humanity recorded thus far indeed demonstrates that the rise and fall of civilizations and the success or failure of nations can be sufficiently explained utilizing sociological theories that completely exclude racism; racism is entirely futile in the cognitive realm. If an individual asserts that a certain race is superior and another race is inferior, exactly where is this disparity manifested? The factual reality is that it fundamentally manifests nowhere; the most

exceptional ethnicities have not transcended the general principles of the social sciences, and identically, neither have the most despised ethnicities.

When an individual frequently utilizes racist theories to explain social issues, they have *de facto* abandoned the contemplation of truth; the consequences are catastrophic. One must realize that during a certain period in our nation's history, countless accidents were universally attributed to "sabotage by enemy agents" (敌特破坏). An individual who inherently endorses racism in their heart finds it virtually impossible to possess a correct cognition of the society in which they reside. Once such imbeciles are allowed to wield power, how could the disastrous consequences possibly descend exclusively upon the heads of the "inferior races" they despise?

Restricting the critique of racism strictly to the moral domain paradoxically conceals its malice, because those explanations that identically interfere with and degrade the public's cognition, yet appear morally milder—such as the so-called "cultural genes" (文化基因)—can exceedingly easily escape people's attention. What exactly is the distinction between interpreting the successes, failures, advantages, and disadvantages of the world as the inherent differences in the cultural genes of distinct ethnicities, and resorting to racism? They are both entirely unfalsifiable; all disparities can be conveniently explained away as differences in race, differences in culture, or differences in people, and the ultimate result is that absolutely nothing has been explained.

Westerners are so fanatically obsessed with moral judgment that they are already utterly incapable of realizing they possess fundamentally zero distinction from the racists they are judging: both are identically utilizing a non-scientific, excessively oversimplified methodology to view the world. This inevitably brings to mind my motherland: during the final phase of the Chinese empire in the Ming and Qing eras, the scholar-officials (士大夫) were identically fanatical about moral issues.

I genuinely harbor a sensation: I do not doubt that the citizens of contemporary Western developed nations, provided they have undergone rational training, can more or less comprehend the works of Western philosophical pioneers; yet they will no longer attempt to—or more disastrously, they are already unaccustomed to—thinking like Plato, Bacon, or Rousseau. Nowadays, people exclusively desire a simplistic, emotionalized answer. Readers reaching this point might assume I am harboring groundless anxieties (杞人忧天). After all, I myself have pointed out that precisely such phenomena occurred during the initial phase of **feudalization** (封建化); who can definitively assert that contemporary Western society is not undergoing yet another "feudalization"? Yet personally, I still harbor doubts regarding whether human civilization, having developed to its present state, truly ought to experience another stage such as the "ebb tide of rationality" (理性的退潮). If asserting that the West is decaying is genuinely too alarmist, then we ought to at least cautiously point out: Western society is currently hemorrhaging certain characteristics that historically sustained the establishment of its absolute advantage over the past several centuries.

If Western society could cease indulging in postmodern culture—which lacks a robust foundation—and instead turn its gaze back to earnestly rediscovering the modern, they naturally would not commit such farcical blunders. Despite the fact that for 1,400 years Islam has never permanently conquered a region that had basically completed *feudalization* (封建化), Westerners still face the Islamic world as if against a grave threat. Conversely, regarding the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚制度) of China—a terrifying threat possessing supreme adaptability and maximum lethality—the Western world remains entirely oblivious, exactly like a blind man.

Do they genuinely believe their democratic system is already robust enough to be invulnerable to all poisons, treating the mechanisms of ruling, tormenting, and domesticating humans that the Chinese have refined over millennia as sheer nothingness? Do they genuinely possess absolute certainty in preventing the emergence of this specific system, which inflicts profound torment upon absolutely everyone in society, from the ruling class at the apex down to the ruled classes at the bottom?

I think not; after all, human beings across the globe harbor fundamentally zero essential distinctions. Since the virus of bureaucratism (官僚主义的病毒) was capable of bringing China to its knees, it is perfectly capable of infecting absolutely any nation.

Numerous Western nations perceive China as a menacing potential adversary, yet they fundamentally possess zero comprehension of exactly what it is that generates this threat. The pro-China factions abroad have no idea exactly who they should align with, while the anti-China factions identically possess zero idea exactly what they are opposing. If Western society persists in observing other regions—which reside in developmental stages diametrically distinct from their own—with such an arrogant and perfunctory attitude, then they will ultimately remain incapable of comprehending themselves. Don Quixote (堂吉珂德) was courageous, but constantly attacking windmills exactly like Don Quixote inevitably guarantees that one will be swallowed by genuine peril while remaining blissfully unaware.

7, 关于当代西方世界的一点看法

虽然我作为中国人不可能多么了解发达国家的政治，但是在我看来，现如今在西方国家尤其是美国明显的政治极化（Political polarization）现象或许就与学界与公众对“现代性”仍然缺乏认知有关。我注意到当年奠定现在西方发达国家立国基石的政治文本中，对于现代性的讨论仍然是比较浅显的。例如在美国的《独立宣言》中，美国的缔造者们宣布“某些真理是不证自明的”，并没有采取直接的说教或者证明方式来说服人们。那个年代人们采取的办法是诉诸理性和自然法，共同经验与价值观，利用修辞技巧与情感共鸣，并且反复强调行动的必要性。然而社会科学毕竟是实践的科学，任何理论在叙述上即使再有说服力，逻辑上即使再严密，不经过历史的检验也是不足为信的。人不可能永远保持理性，来自五湖四海的移民难以拥有一致的经验和价值观，修辞和情感诉求调动的激情难以长久，而当年行动的必要性，随着时间的推移，也会被人们所遗忘。更何况任何社会的发展都不可能一帆风顺，经济发展遇到的困难再加上少数人的有意推动，民众就很容易怀疑自己国家立国的基本价值观和政治体制。

西方世界的现状在我这样的非西方国家居民观察中是什么样子呢？我认为西方国家既不自信又过度自信，这样看似矛盾的两种倾向互为因果。说他们不自信，原因是西方社会似乎无法从人类历史进程中推演出“现代性”的由来，从而确信自身的成功是长期发展的必然结果，并非短时段的事件能左右的。我的确理解他们的担忧，毕竟上个世纪的“马克思列宁主义者”一直试图宣扬一种认为历史是一个有方向、有目的的演化过程的决定论观点，并且真的造成了极其巨大的破坏。但是这种恐惧未必不会演变成成为一种“杯弓蛇影”的状态，这对于人类认识自身没有好处。如这篇记录所示，我们完全可以在不假定各个社会的历史演进具有统一的方向和目的的情况下探索可能存在的普遍规律。说他们自信，原因是西方社会既然演化到了现代社会这个阶段，却在连“现代性”都缺乏认识的情况下热衷于讨论“后现代性”（Postmodernity）。我也能够理解这种狂妄，毕竟冷战胜利和技术革命对于西方人的冲击确实太大。问题在于，如果人们连现代是怎么来的都不知道，那么又如何得知什么是现代之后呢？沉溺于对后现代性的讨论就很难不让进步派的观点在相当一部分人口看来过于离经叛道，这显然给予了保守派人士话柄。民众出于对“漫无目的且毫无节制的进步”的担忧和厌恶，就可能投入保守派的阵营，以至于使刹车变成倒车。

如果西方世界能够真正意识到自己其实连现代性都没有研究清楚，并且把目光放回到那些早就应该讨论出结果的问题上，那么导致政治极化的相当大一部分原因就已经解决了。诚如本记录所言，一旦我们通过对历史的观察认识到了统一的社会学规律的存在，这就足以大大增强人们对于普世价值观念的信心。西方人至少应该有一种坚实的信心，而不是像现在人们看到的一样总在自大和自卑之间摇摆不定。

这样人们至少可以从思想上把过左的派别向后拉一拉，把过右的派别向前拽一拽，让已经极化的民主政治能够缓和一些。当然，要想解决民主国家所面临的困境最终还是要落实到经济上，这根本不是我一个外人能够置喙的。我在落笔写这样一份记录的时候，最初不过是想以世界各国为镜子照出中国的过往和现实。但是当我快要写完的时候，我发现对于世界上其他国家而言，中国何尝是不是一面能够照清自己的镜子。我现在发自内心地感受到人类各个国家、各个民族的命运是相连的，但是我们彼此之间相互了解还太少。大家在同一个地球村（Global village），但是看待对方却如同陌生人，由此观之全球化不是发展地太过了，而是还远远不够啊！

我之前几次提到为什么我坚决反对种族主义，其实我对于种族主义的观点就能和当今西方社会的主流看法构成明显的对比。在我看来，反对种族主义首先是反对愚昧而非道德批判。人类迄今为止记录的历史的确表明，文明兴亡国家成败足以用排除种族主义的社会学理论来解释，种族主义在认知领域是完全无益的。如果一个人说某个种族优越，而另一个种族卑劣，那么这种差异体现在何处呢？事实就是完全体现不出来，再优秀的民族也没有超脱社会科学的一般原理，那些最被瞧不起的民族也是如此。当一个人频繁地把社会问题用种族主义的理论来解释时，他在事实上就放弃了对于真理的思考，其后果是灾难性的。要知道在我国历史上也曾有那么一段时间，无数事故都被人们归咎于“敌特破坏”。一个心里认可种族主义的人，几乎不可能对于自己生活的社会具有正确的认识，一旦让这种愚蠢之人掌握权力，恶果又怎么会恰恰只降到它认为的劣等民族头上。把对种族主义的批判限定在道德上，反倒是为其隐恶，因为那些同样干扰和劣化民众认知，但是在道德上更加温和的解释就很容易逃脱人们的注意，比如说所谓的“文化基因”。把天下的成败利钝解释为不同民族固有的文化基因不同，和诉诸于种族主义又有什么区别呢？它们都是全然不可验的，所有的不同都可以解释为种族不同，文化不同以及人不同，最终的结果是什么也没有解释。

西方人如此痴迷于道德审判，却已经无法意识到已经与被自己审判的种族主义者没有差异了：两者同样都是在用一种非科学的过度简单的方法来看待世界。这不禁让人想起在我的祖国，中华帝国在明清时期的最后阶段里，士大夫们也是如此地热衷于道德问题。我确有一种感觉，我不怀疑当代西方发达国家的公民只要经受过合理的训练都可以多少理解西方先哲们的作品，但是他们已经不会尝试，或者更灾难性的是，他们已经不习惯于像柏拉图、培根、卢梭等人一样思考。现在人们只想要一个简单的，情绪化的答案。读到这里的读者或许会认为我杞人忧天，毕竟我自己也指出在封建化开始的阶段曾经就发生过这般事，谁又能说得清楚今天的西方社会不是在经历另一场“封建化”呢？但我个人仍然怀疑人类文明发展到如今，是不是还应该出现“理性的退潮”这样一个阶段。如果说西方正在衰落实在是过于危言耸听，那么我们至少也应该谨慎地指出：西方社会正在丧失一些曾经在过去数个世纪中支撑其建立优势的特征。

如果西方社会能够不沉溺于缺少坚实基础的后现代文化，而是转过头来认真地重新发现现代，他们自然就不会做出啼笑皆非之事。明明一千四百年来伊斯兰从来没有长久征服过一个基本完成封建化的地区，西方人面对伊斯兰世界却如临大敌。反倒是中国复辟官僚制度这样一种适应性极强，危害性极大的恐怖威胁，西方世界却如同盲人一样全然没有察觉。难道他们真的觉得自己的民主制度已经强大到足以百毒不侵，视中国人的千百年间所精进的统治、折磨和驯化人的手段于无物吗？他们真的有十足的把握防止这种让社会中的所有人，上到统治阶级下到被统治阶级都深受其害的体制出现吗？我看未必如此，毕竟世界各地的人类在本质上没什么区别。既然官僚主义的病毒能够把中国撂倒，那它就可能感染任何一个国家。很多西方国家认为中国是具有威胁的潜在敌人，但是它们根本不知道究竟能产生威胁的是什么。外国的亲华者不知道该亲近谁，反华者也不知道该反对什么。如果西方社会依然以如此傲慢的态度草率地看待其他与自身所处阶段截然不同的地区，那么它也最终无法认识自己。堂吉诃德是勇敢的，但总是像堂吉诃德一样攻击风车，就免不了会在浑然不觉中被真正的危险所吞没。